My own sense is that Shah is a bit of a split personality. He could be warm and approachable in private conversation, with a sharp sense of humour. But he is also a ruthless politician who believes in a '*saam, daam, dand, bhed*' brand of politics where ends mattered more than the means adopted. Whether the ruthlessness extended to ordering extra-judicial killings, is a matter for the courts to decide; but clearly, the numerous controversies which have swirled around him suggest that Shah still has much explaining to do.

There is no doubt, though, that he's someone who relishes a political fight. Maybe it was this dogged determination to prove himself that made Shah the ideal person to take on the tough UP challenge. Within days of being made campaign committee chief in June 2013, Modi ensured that Shah was fully empowered as general secretary in charge of UP. The right-hand man who had been his 'eyes and ears' in Gujarat was now being asked to be his brain in the most crucial battle of 2014. UP offered the biggest prize of eighty seats. Most observers reckoned the BJP needed to win at least forty to fifty seats to have any chance of achieving Mission 272-plus. The odds were stacked against the man from Sarkhej. But they had also been against him when he had spent two months in Sabarmati jail. Now was redemption time.

When Shah arrived at the BJP office in Lucknow on 12 June 2013, he was aware of the magnitude of the task facing him. The state BJP unit was totally demoralized—the party had been out of power in UP for seventeen years with little hope of a comeback. Its leadership was ageing and warring with each other. Some of the old guards saw Shah as an 'outsider' who was being thrust on them. UP politicians tend to have an exaggerated sense of self-importance and believe that no one knows their state like they do. '*Gujarat aur UP mein bahut fark hai, Amitji*' (There's a huge difference between Gujarat and UP), one of them openly told Shah. One of the new general secretary's first acts was to call day-long meetings, in small groups, of all the party MPs and MLAs who had won and lost elections. 'It's important to know why we were losing elections, why our voters had deserted us,' was his reasoning.